

and other environments that are not USB-aware. Enable only if you need to use an USB keyboard in a DOS environment, for example, flashing your BIOS from a DOS boot disk.

2.5 Updating (flashing) the BIOS and other firmware

Taking advantage of the capabilities offered by EEPROM, motherboard manufacturers have begun releasing new versions of the BIOS with greater frequency these days. There are many reasons that an update to the BIOS may be required: the new version offers better stability, compatibility or performance; new technical breakthroughs require new features in the BIOS; a device attached to the computer may not function without the newer version; and increasingly, flashes fix some problems in the earlier version of the BIOS!

Warning

Never Flash The BIOS Unless Absolutely Essential!

In the old days, when you wanted to upgrade/update your BIOS, you had one of two options: change the motherboard or replace the chip with a newer model. With the introduction of EEPROM (Electrically Erasable and Programmable Read Only Memory) it has now become possible to update the BIOS via software.

Just as the PC motherboard has a BIOS chip, so do other hardware components and peripherals. These include things such as the video card, the CD-ROM/RW, DVD-ROM/RW, etc. Generally, the BIOSes on these are known as firmware. And just as the PC BIOS can be updated, the BIOS of these devices can be updated, too. While we only cover flashing the PC BIOS, the procedure is pretty similar for other firmware. In all cases, make sure you have all the information and the procedure down before the procedure.

Updating, or flashing as it's popularly known, the BIOS should only be undertaken if everything else fails and you have sufficient reason to believe that flashing your BIOS will help. The golden